THE MAKING OF **A CHAMP**



FEB. 18, 2002

Born to Ramkishan, a chief engineer in the merchant navy, and Sumedha, a Sanskrit teacher, in Goria, Haryana. Named after Manikarnika a.k.a Jhansi ki Rani

2016



At Universal Higher Senior Secondary School in Goria, Manu, 14, is asked to leave the history class for either "sleeping or eating" (she can't recall which). Runs into a friend who suggests they head to the school's shooting range. Discovers she's born to shoot



Heena Sidhu

2017

- After struggling to get an arms licence earlier in the year, the 15-year-old rookie caps it by upsetting Olympian and then world #3 Heena Sidhu in the national shooting championships
- Makes a splash in the international circuit after a silver at the Asian junior championships

2018



- In her maiden ISSF World Cup at Guadalajara, Mexico, makes it to the finals in a field comprising Olympic champion Anna Korakaki. Wins gold to become the youngest Indian to do so at the competition. Also wins mixed team event with Prakash Mitharval
- Breaks Commonwealth Games record to clinch gold in 10m air pistol event in Brisbane
- Becomes first Indian shooter to win gold in 10m air pistol at Summer Youth Olympics, Buenos Aires

2019

Teaming up with Saurabh Chaudhary, dominates 10m air pistol mixed team event, winning all four editions of the ISSF World Cup. Duo emerges as favourites for Tokyo Games



2021



- Makes it to Tokyo 2020 team in 10m air pistol, 10m air pistol mixed and 25m pistol events. But it's all downhill thereafter: her pistol malfunctions in 10m air pistol qualification, Bhaker-Chaudhary finish 7th in stage 2 qualification for 10m air pistol mixed, and Manu fails to qualify for 25 m pistol

Wandering aimlessly in the schoolgrounds, she ran into a friend, who suggested they hit the shooting range to kill time. Coach Anil Jakhar was impressed by her upper body strength, which Manu attributes to boxing. He put spurs on her casual curiosity. Within a year, Manu had her foot in the national squad, the 15-year-old displacing the senior and then world #3 Heena Sidhu in the national championships, marking a key turning point. She would soon win her first international medal at the Asian Junior Championships. Manu had arrived.

By 16, she would come under the tutelage of Jaspal Rana, then the junior coach of the national team. As someone who encourages his pupils to maintain a diary detailing their training schedule and scores, Rana was impressed with Manu's discipline. What he saw was "a child who goes through intense training and pushes herself to the limit", he recalls. "I have had to push her out from the range many times." What unfolded thereafter may well be called the Manu era. In 2018, at her maiden ISSF World Cup in Mexico, she outshot Olympic champion Anna Korakaki to win gold; she then broke the Commonwealth Games Record to clinch gold in 10m air pistol in Australia and became the first Indian shooter to win gold again in 10m air pistol at the Buenos Aires Summer Youth Olympics. In 2019, she and Saurabh Chaudhary dominated the 10m air pistol mixed team, winning all four editions of the ISSF World Cup. But just when she had hit what athletes dream of —the 'zone'—the Covid-19 pandemic in 2020 halted her momentum. Deemed medal favourites, Chaudhary and Bhaker returned empty-handed from Tokyo the next year.